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## The Life of the Unborn: Notions from Bernard Lonergan\*



The “termination” of so many young lives—in the United States alone, a million and a half each year—lives that would otherwise have issued in the birth of children, members of the human race, must be traumatic for those immediately involved: the lawyers and moralists who deal with the legal and ethical aspects; the pastors who help the troubled to form their consciences and to be true to their responsibilities; above all the persons who are co-creators with God of this young life, the ones on whom the decision, whichever it is, will weigh most heavily, the potential parents.

The decisions taken in this area are not just traumatic for those immediately involved; they raise a question of conscience for everyone, even for those who work in the remoter areas of academe, and we must all respond to that question. We must do so now, for those millions of lives are being terminated now, and we may not shirk our present responsibilities until such time as we have answers for all the questions that occur to us. It is not just the right to life that is at stake, but very great and fundamental values over a wide range, values formed in our history, handed on in our traditions, enshrined in our laws, shared by a community. In the breakdown of community, and the challenging of ancient values, in a situation where the understanding that might assure consensus is lacking, we must form our consciences as best we can on short-range and *ad hoc* criteria, and fall back on authority when intrinsic reasons and long-range principles fail us.

Those, however, who work in those remoter areas of academe that I mentioned have a further obligation: to work toward the long-term understanding that is essential to a peaceful solution of the issues. In this they have the paradigm of a principle laid down and a pattern traced centuries ago by Thomas Aquinas. Asked once whether we should settle disputes by authority or by reason, he answered that, when it is a question of truth in theology, one has recourse to authority. Not

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so when it is a question of understanding; then one must go to the heart of the matter, using our powers of reasoning. Otherwise, he says, students may subscribe to the truth being taught, but lacking understanding they will go away with empty minds.<sup>1</sup>

In the area under discussion the need for understanding is urgent. The need, of course, is always there, even in regard to the truth that is revealed by God, the most sacred articles of our faith. We can individually bow to authority, set aside the ideas that would question it, and suppress the views that would contradict it. But we cannot count on the human race as a whole to submit in this way. As Newman said on the most fundamental Catholic doctrine, that of the Trinity: "it was impossible to go on using words [those of the baptismal formula] without an insight into their meaning."<sup>2</sup> Now what applies to revealed truth applies also and *a fortiori* to the truth we must gain in struggle and achievement, and it applies *par excellence* and with great urgency to truth in the field of human conduct. There is a helpful witness to that in the decision Bernard Lonergan made in his last years, to devote his remaining time and energy to the study of economics—on the ground that our moral theology had been issuing in this field precepts based on a quite inadequate economic science. Moral theology, I think he would have said, can no more do without a valid economics than systematic theology can do without a valid philosophy.

All this is relevant to what I wish to attempt in this essay. My field of work is located in the remoter areas of academe, but I cannot be indifferent either to those millions of lives being terminated annually, or the other millions who must make decisions on the life of the unborn. Next, the influence of Thomas Aquinas and of his position on understanding and authority has given me a lifelong and basic orientation. Then, thirdly, there is the influence that has been most direct and potent, that of Lonergan; the example of his pastoral interest in economics validates for me the impulse to take up the present question, and to try to contribute something, not indeed to the whole range of issues involved, but to the one quite limited task of understanding the life of the unborn.

That does not mean at all that I will try to do here what Lonergan has done in economics. His efforts were deployed on two levels: that of an underlying philosophy of humankind and human history, with notions of human intentionality and human intersubjectivity, of human development and human institutions, etc.; and the level proper to eco-

1. *Quodlibetum* IV, q. 9, a. 3: "Utrum magister determinando quaestiones theologicas debeat uti ratione, vel auctoritate."

2. John Henry Newman, *Tracts Theological and Ecclesiastical* (London: Longmans, Green, 1924 [1874]), p. 152.

nomics, with its specific ideas and principles. My contribution in the field of the life sciences will be confined to the level of an underlying philosophy. It will not then by itself give an understanding of the life of the unborn, much less suffice for an ethics in regard to the unborn. But I would maintain that the life sciences and ethics need the level of philosophy for a perspective on what they are doing.

One more remark on the relation of this essay to Lonergan. It is not just method and procedures that I will owe to him, but the content of the essay as well. But, since the ideas to be adduced belong more to the class he would call heuristic, that is, directing investigation rather than defining results, I will follow his usage and speak of them as notions. As heuristic, they will not come to any conclusions about the life of the unborn in respect to its specific quality; nevertheless, I hope that those engaged in the life sciences will find them helpful, especially those familiar with Lonergan's work. To the latter I would say that my contribution is neither interpretation nor development of Lonergan. I simply bring together three loca in his writings that at present lie apart, that brought together in sequence and unity may throw a revealing light on the life of the unborn. They deal respectively (1) with soul as the intelligible component of living matter, (2) with finality as the immanent intelligibility of developing material reality, and (3) with self-mediation as the route taken by an organism to reach its developed state.

## I. Soul as Intelligible

I turn first to work that Lonergan did forty years ago in the context of his theology. His particular question need not concern us here, but its elaboration took him deep into Thomist cognitional theory, where he dealt with the role of understanding in forming our concepts, and with the reality of that component of material beings which is grasped through understanding. In illustration he had recourse to an example of the keenest present interest: the intelligible component of living things—that which we call “soul.”<sup>3</sup>

The word, of course, has taken on connotations that are many and various, and not all of them valid or happy. But we can leave most of them aside in dealing with the Aristotelian notion. Soul here is a perfectly straightforward object of scientific study. It is not, however, a distinct material element of reality; but neither is it a submerged meta-

3. Publication began in *Theological Studies* 7 (1946) and continued into 10 (1949). The articles were later collected and published in book form as *Verbum: Word and Idea in Aquinas* (Notre Dame: University of Notre Dame, 1967). Reference will be made to this volume.

physical element in the sense of something beyond apprehension, much less of a ghost in a machine. To look for the soul is not to search in a dark room for a black object that does not exist. It is rather to do what every scientist continually aims at doing, discovering the intelligibility of the material object being investigated. Now that intelligibility is the object of understanding, and soul is simply a special case of the intelligible, whether we deal with the intelligibility of vegetative life in the plant, of sensitive life in the animal, or of rational life in the human being. If the scientist discovers an intelligible element unifying the data provided by the material entity we call human, that scientist has discovered the human soul. I quote:

Aristotle's basic thesis was the objective reality of what is known by understanding. . . . When, then, Aristotle calls the soul a *logos*, he is stating his highly original position, not indeed with the full accuracy which his thought alone made possible, but in a generic fashion which suited his immediate purpose; and it is that generic issue that remains the capital issue, for the denial of soul today is really the denial of the intelligible, the denial that understanding, knowing a cause, is knowing anything real.<sup>4</sup>

The simple conclusion I would draw from this position is that the issue in regard to human soul does not regard something distinct and separate, but exactly the contrary: it regards a unity-identity-whole.<sup>5</sup> So

4. *Verbum*, pp. 20–21. Note that soul, or universally the formal cause, is the *directly* intelligible component; other components of material reality are intelligible in and through the form.

Some traditional scholastic distinctions will illuminate Lonergan's use of the word "component." As a first approximation, there are "parts" of matter, as when one divides a pie. There are the somewhat different material "parts" of a living body, as when one considers hands, feet, etc. And there are the logical "parts" of a definition, as when one defines "man" as a "rational [specific difference] animal [genus]." But when we speak of soul as form we are talking about the "components" that scholastic philosophy names "potency," "form," and "act." This is a use of the word "component" that is very different from that which equates it with a material "part" or even a logical "part." The components in question now are a unity corresponding to the unity of the process by which we know them. That is, just as there are three levels of cognitional activity—experiencing, understanding, and affirming—that make up a single knowing, so also the contents of the knowing make up a single known, and the reality known is a unity. We do not know a first being by experiencing, a second by understanding, and a third by affirming.

To come to the present application, we are speaking of a scientific explanation of living things. A scientific explanation is a theory verified in instances. As verified, it refers to the component called "act"; as theory, it refers to the component called "form"; as instantiated, it refers to the component called "potency." Thus a human being is a unity: as existing in act, as informed by soul, as "this" being at this point in space-time. What is important to grasp here is this: soul is not a submerged metaphysical entity in the sense of a black object in a dark room. It is the real component known in scientific explanation, the intelligible form of what we see, hear, touch, in this instance of flesh and bones. It is in this sense that "soul" is a component. (On all this, see *Insight: A Study of Human Understanding*, pp. 431–34.)

5. See *Insight*, esp. ch. 8, "Things"; e.g., p. 248: "Thus, the thing is the basic synthetic

that we would not establish the existence of a human soul by finding some distinct entity or element, but then neither do we falsify the affirmation of that existence by not finding some distinct entity or element. This much can be said, I think, without elaborating a cognitive theory or an epistemology or a metaphysics; no doubt all these are ultimately involved, but scientists may feel, justly enough, that these areas not only lie outside their terms of reference, but are not needed for valid science. I would agree that our spontaneously operative cognitive dynamism, our natural epistemology, and our latent metaphysics will serve us quite well in the field of science; but it can hardly harm our investigations to have a more accurate notion of what we are looking for, or not looking for.

## II. Finality as the Intelligible Factor in Development

Our second locus is found in *Insight*, Lonergan's independent cognitive theory and philosophy, published some ten years after his work on Aquinas. The discussion still has to do with intelligibility, so this point is in series with the previous one, but specifically now with the intelligibility of development. The progress from the Thomist studies is therefore from the intelligibility of an entity that could be conceived somewhat statically to the intelligibility of a developing entity in its development, that is, we have moved to the law of growth of material things—in particular of that material thing which is a human body.

The key word here becomes "finality," but it should be noted at once, for the avoidance of much misunderstanding, that finality is not the final causality of the Scholastics; that was an extrinsic cause, but Lonergan's finality, denoting an immanent intelligibility, would pertain to an intrinsic cause, just as much as does the *logos* which Aristotle discovered in material reality. Nor is finality to be *imagined*, as though it were some very thin, very strong towline pulling the material reality

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construct of scientific thought and development. It embraces in a concrete unity a totality of spatially and temporally distinct data." It is central form that grounds this unity; in the present case, the human soul. Perhaps it will help toward an understanding of these ideas to quote a paragraph from Lonergan's chapter, "Things":

"Now the notion of a thing is grounded in an insight that grasps, not relations between data, but a unity, identity, whole in data; and this unity is grasped, not by considering data from any abstractive viewpoint, but by taking them in their concrete individuality and in the totality of their aspects. For if the reader will turn his mind to any object he names a thing, he will find that object to be a unity to which belongs every aspect of every datum within the unity. Thus, the dog, Fido, is a unity and to Fido is ascribed a totality of data whether of colour or shape, sound or odour, feeling or movement. Moreover, from this grasp of unity in a concrete totality of data there follow the various characteristics of things" (*Insight*, p. 246).

into the future, or a jet engine somewhere within the body. Finality, then, does not pertain to fancy but to fact, to the present reality of this particular body, but to that reality as intelligible, and specifically to its development as intelligible.

What then is finality? It is the dynamic aspect of the real. It is not merely dynamism but directed dynamism. The direction does not, in the most general case, come from a determinate form toward which it is pointed, for generically the dynamism has the indeterminacy of Thomist prime matter, and is a feature of the whole material universe. Nevertheless, it is not nothing. Neither is it directionless; but the direction is that of the law of effective probability. Finality is "an immanent intelligibility operating through the effective probability of possibility."<sup>6</sup>

Thus far, finality as a dynamic aspect conceived with the generality of Thomist prime matter. But that is only the start of the story. With the realization of initial possibilities, the dynamic aspect does not vanish, the developing reality does not cease its onward and upward drive; on the contrary it is open to, and propelled toward, higher and higher integrations. But—and this point will become crucial for the life of the unborn—the higher the integration is, the less dependence there is on that substratum of potency (the "coincidental manifold") which is subject to the law of effective probability. Thus we find that in the organism, in the psyche, and in intelligence, there is an independence of those lower quantities that are so important for probabilities. So Lonergan remarks, in a kind of *reductio ad absurdum*, that "the meaning of one's dreams is not a function of one's weight, and one's ability in mathematics does not vary with one's height."<sup>7</sup>

What does all this mean for our topic? It was written around thirty-five years ago and, though it was illustrated through organic, as well as psychic and intellectual development, and has therefore a broad application, it was not meant specifically as a philosophy of developing life in the unborn. Nevertheless, as a study of genetic method at the most basic level, it will pertain to the development of embryo and fetus too, as it does to the development of child and adult. Its relevance, however, is rather that of a heuristic notion than that of a determinate idea. Hence Lonergan concludes his exposition with the remark: "It

6. *Insight*, p. 448. It is important to distinguish the probability that is effective in the physical world from the probability that is a quality of a judgment. The latter is an effort of the mind to reach truth, but unable to do so with certainty. The former is operational in the physical universe to bring about events—hence, *effective* probability. See *Insight*, pp. 67–68, 550.

7. *Ibid.*, p. 463.

has all been, of course, very general. It is meant to be so. A heuristic structure is only the framework in which investigation is to introduce specific laws and particular facts."<sup>8</sup>

Methodologists, along with philosophers and theologians, would be out of their element in trying to determine those specific laws and particular facts. That does not mean they have nothing relevant to say; there is, in fact, a third and immensely important notion to be introduced now from the general area of method and philosophy.

### III. Life as Self-Mediation

This third notion emerged a decade after Lonergan had finished writing *Insight*, when he became interested in the term "mediation" and worked out its meaning for lectures in the summer of 1963 at Gonzaga University in Spokane and Thomas More Institute in Montreal. At the latter institution the lecture was entitled "The Mediation of Christ in Prayer," and it was under this title that the Spokane and Montreal materials were recently collated and published.<sup>9</sup> But the philosophical part can be studied quite independently of its application to the prayer of Christ; it proceeds, in typical Lonergan fashion, through the notions of "Mediation in General" (pp. 1-4), "Mutual Mediation: The Functional Whole" (pp. 4-6), "Self-Mediation" (pp. 6-12), to come to "Mutual Self-Mediation" (pp. 12-14). Our interest is in "Self-Mediation," which divides into subsections on "Living" (pp. 6-8), "Consciousness" (pp. 8-9), and "Self-Consciousness" (pp. 9-12). Sooner or later Lonergan's views on consciousness should be applied to the data we have on consciousness in the unborn, but that would mean a whole new study, so for economy of presentation I restrict present discussion to the self-mediation we find generically in the living organism.

An obvious starting point is the distinction between machines and organisms: "Both . . . are functional wholes; but machines are made while organisms grow." Lonergan proceeds to the explanation of this growth: "The growth of an organism is a self-mediation. The organism originates itself by giving rise to physical parts within itself. Such growth is a process of division. . . ." Then, linking this notion with our second section above, he adds: "The process of division is governed by a finality."<sup>10</sup>

We shall presently notice the extent to which finality governs the division, and is operative in the developing life of the organism, but

8. *Ibid.*, p. 478.

9. *Method: Journal of Lonergan Studies* 2/1 (March, 1984), pp. 1-20.

10. *Ibid.*, p. 6.



meanwhile it will be worth our while to fill in some details in the description of self-mediation. Consider then the following lines:

At any stage of its growth the organism is alive at that stage and preparing later stages. As alive at that stage, it is a set of functional parts in a functional whole. There are different centers of immediacy, with the centers giving the whole all the properties of each of the centers. But as moving from one stage to another it will exhibit transitional developments, useful for a time but later disappearing. It is extremely useful for the infant, for example, to be able to feed at the breast, but it is just a transitional development. On the other hand, moving from one stage to another the organism will exhibit anticipatory developments that have no great utility at the given stage but are extremely useful or essential later on. For example, the size of the child's brain is out of proportion to the rest of its body, but the brain does not increase in bulk the way the rest of the body does. In other words, there is something more than mutual mediation to the organism. There is the structuring which regards both functioning at the moment *and* future functioning.<sup>11</sup>

Let us return to the finality that governs the division of cells. As the reader will expect, the resulting growth is much more than a matter of mere increase in size; there is a process of specialization or differentiation, and this process "involves the creation and exploitation of entirely new possibilities." But the finality of the developing organism is not exhausted even by the process of specialization. We come then to the notion that is the most immediately relevant one I have found in Lonergan to the life of the unborn.

The organism lives, it has a reality that is superior to the whole business of cells and their differentiation and specialization. This living is quite different in kind from the living of the single cells or the multitude of single cells. It is the living of the whole organism. A higher set of functions emerges on the renewable substratum and develops and sustains itself, as it were, on a higher level . . . The *telos* is the self-developing and self-sustaining functional whole that develops through the development and functions through the functioning of its parts.<sup>12</sup>

In this passage we have an epitome of what Lonergan has added to Aristotle and Aquinas on the concept of the soul. Soul, they would agree, is the directly intelligible component of the living thing. But in this material universe things develop according to laws that neither Aristotle nor Aquinas would have been able to formulate in detail, laws which Lonergan was able to pin down through his notion of immanent finality. Finality, however, if Lonergan is right, operates quite differently in living and non-living things, and among living things quite differently in the lower and the higher forms of life. In the higher forms, self-mediation more and more replaces the indeterminacy of the merely

11. Ibid., pp. 6-7.

12. Ibid., p. 7.

potential and even the law of effective probability. The Aristotelian concept of the soul as *logos* is now found to have unsuspected possibilities; it not only unifies the data in their static reality but governs and unifies as well the whole process of development from the beginning.

We have to ask science to determine whether or not self-mediation operates in this way, as we have to ask science to determine "specific laws and particular facts" in every area of the life sciences. Nonetheless, we are entitled to explain, from the side of a philosophy, and to ask science to understand, just what the question is that is being asked. There is a parallel here with the point made earlier in regard to soul: if we are looking for a distinct material element, or for a submerged metaphysical entity, or maybe for a ghost in a machine, we will only conclude that soul does not exist; but if we grasp the role of understanding in apprehending reality, and arrive also at an understanding of a unity-identity-whole that centers all the correlations science studies in things, then we may well conclude to the existence of "soul," however unhappy we may consider the term itself. Similarly, if in our search for finality we look for that tow-rope leading reality into the future, we will regard it as a myth exploded long ago by methodical science; but if we look instead for the intelligibility of development, as a scientific account of phenomena that were treated in the infancy of the science as chance variation, then we are at least open to the possibility of discovering finality in the material universe. To come, then, to the present aspect of the question, if we think of self-mediation as the life-science equivalent of lifting oneself by one's bootstraps, we will hardly be bothered even to look for it; but if we understand it as the intelligibility of a structuring that is dynamic, that dynamically brings to realization what lies within the potency of the dynamism, then we may or may not find it, but at least we have not ruled it out of court in advance by a misunderstanding of the question.

There is an illuminating analogy here with the dynamism of human knowing. The latter operates consciously, and we are abstracting here from the conscious; nevertheless, it is in order to notice the self-assembling pattern in the more familiar field of human knowing, and through that analogy obtain some understanding of the less familiar organic field. Human knowing then involves many distinct activities, none of which by itself may be called human knowing. It is the combination, under the influence of a dynamic structure, that constitutes human knowing. But the combination is self-assembling.

Experience stimulates inquiry, and inquiry is intelligence bringing itself to act; it leads from experience through imagination to insight, and from insight to the concepts that combine in single objects both what has been grasped by

insight and what in experience or imagination is relevant to the insight. In turn, concepts stimulate reflection, and reflection is the conscious exigence of rationality; it marshals the evidence and weighs it either to judge or else to doubt and so renew inquiry.<sup>13</sup>

Through this analogy, maybe, those of us who are not experts in the field can gain some understanding of the way an organism "develops through the development and functions through the functioning of its parts."

Nevertheless, it is not analogous but proper understanding that we seek, and such understanding is the province of those who collect and classify and study the data of the life sciences. Will they be helped by the foregoing notions? That is for them to say. I only hope that they will not speak prematurely on the matter, without considering the teamwork that a combination of heuristic notions with determinate data and concepts may make possible; without asking, in their quest for understanding, how understanding works and thereby come to some methodical and very fruitful insights into what they are doing.<sup>14</sup>

13. *Collection: Papers by Bernard Lonergan*, p. 223.

14. On the other side, I have to ask myself whether these ideas, so sketchily traced, will contribute anything to understanding the life of the unborn in its specific quality. I have no answer to that question, but the gravity of the situation leads me to offer my study for publication in the hope, or at least on the chance, that it may help; it is a situation in which we must all do what we can, however futile the effort may turn out to be.

In any case, I have to thank Edward Sheridan, Bela Somfai, and Michael Stogre, for reading my essay and providing very helpful critiques.